



RESIDENTS are evacuated Jan. 8 from an Altadena senior facility as fire approached. It is still unclear why alerts to flee were uneven.

ANALYSIS

A lot is riding on Trump’s L.A. visit

Trip will shed light on whether president and Gov. Newsom can set aside partisan politics to aid a state in crisis.

By Taryn Luna

SACRAMENTO — California Gov. Gavin Newsom and President Trump shared a surprisingly symbiotic relationship during the Republican’s first term in the White House, with their public sparring and ability to work together in times of crisis elevating both politicians.

Whether the two men can overcome an ugly 2024 election cycle and resume a respectful rapport for the benefit of Californians should become clearer when Trump surveys wildfire damage in Los Angeles County, possibly as soon as Friday.

The visit gives the president an opportunity to show that during a disaster, he can rise above partisanship and name-calling to provide aid to Americans in need, regardless of whom they voted for in November.

The stakes are considerable for Newsom, who finds himself in a precarious position with his state on fire.

The Democratic governor could end the day with a presidential example of acting like a level-headed leader capable of putting politics — and personal feelings — aside to help his state. Or, Newsom could walk away more vulnerable to criticism that his political gamesmanship and thirst for the national spotlight compromised his ability to deliver for Californians.

“We’re going to learn with this week’s visit whether Donald Trump and Gavin Newsom will treat each other as the president of the United States and the governor of California, or two individuals with completely opposite ideologies who have been sparring continuously,” said Thad Kousser, a professor of political science at UC San Diego.

Trump said over the weekend that he was planning to visit Southern California on Friday, but has not released any details about his trip.

Regardless of when the president visits, Kousser said, a disaster provides an easy “political script” for

[See Analysis, A8]

Rents rise with fire refugees

The Palisades and Eaton blazes have destroyed or damaged more than 8,500 homes in an already tight housing market

By Andrew Khouri and Jack Flemming

When the flames destroyed Ria Cousineau’s Altadena house and damaged the home of her partner, Emily Allen, a horrific situation gave way to what felt like an impossible task.

In an effort to find a semipermanent home while they rebuild, Cousineau estimated the couple toured about 10 houses over four or five days, with one house seeing at least 30 families stroll through in just 10 minutes. Under pressure, they offered to pay \$250 more per month than the asking price on a Pasadena rental.

Although Cousineau said some prospective tenants

More than 11,000 residential structures damaged* or destroyed

Eaton	
Mobile homes	1
Multifamily properties	98
Single-family residence	6,043
Palisades	
Mobile homes	251
Multifamily properties	145
Single-family residences	5,067

*Damage to 25% or more of the structure. Data is as of Jan. 22. California Department of Forestry and Fire Protection Damage Inspection Data

Sandhya Kambhampati Los Angeles Times



THE SANTA YNEZ Reservoir in Pacific Palisades before the Jan. 7 wildfire. The 117-million-gallon reservoir had been drained to await repair of a tear in its cover.

offered more, they were first and accepted.

“We didn’t know what we were going to do,” said Cousineau, 65. “I feel so lucky.”

The fires that tore through Altadena and Pacific Palisades have created a mad rush for a place to live, as thousands of newly homeless families enter what already was a housing market in crisis.

In interviews, housing and disaster recovery experts said that in the long-run the crisis’ effect on housing isn’t certain, but at least in the short term it’s likely to put swift upward pressure on rents in areas near the destruction as the displaced try to stay near their communities.

[See Housing, A9]

Why reservoir was high and dry

Storage was built to protect Palisades, but it was of no use during firestorm because of a months-old problem.

By Matt Hamilton and David Zahniser

After flames leveled nearly 500 homes in Bel-Air and Brentwood in 1961, Los Angeles had a reckoning over firefighting.

By 1964, city leaders had added 13 fire stations,

Flaws still plague alert system

Despite upgrades, emergency warnings can be ineffective when most needed.

By Jenny Jarvie

When the federal government in 2012 launched Wireless Emergency Alerts — a new system that allowed officials to send loud, screeching alarms to cellphones across a large area — many local emergency management officers were wary of the technology.

In 2017, as the Tubbs fire engulfed Northern California’s wine country, officials in Sonoma and Napa counties decided against sending such mass wireless alerts, worrying that they would cause county-wide gridlock and panic. Instead, they relied on an older system that sent messages to a smaller number of landlines and cellphone numbers voluntarily submitted by residents. Ultimately, 22 people perished.

A year later, when the Camp fire swept through the town of Paradise, officials did not use Wireless Emergency Alerts technology, opting for a system that sent out evacuation orders to less than a third of residents. Eighty-five people died, prompting a litany of investigations, reports and calls for statewide reform.

Today, jurisdictions across the state have adopted the up-to-date wireless alert technology. The federal system has also become more sophisticated, allowing operators to issue more precise, targeted warnings. But even with technological advances, problems remain.

As massive fires engulfed the Los Angeles area this month, the problem was not that officials failed to use ad-

[See Alerts, A9]

President’s water policy of ‘people over fish’ faulted

By Ian James

In one of the first acts of his second term, President Trump is seeking to put his stamp on California water policy by directing the federal government to put “people over fish” and send more water from Northern California to the Central Valley’s

farms and Southern California cities.

Trump issued a memorandum Monday ordering federal agencies to restart work to “route more water” from the Sacramento-San Joaquin River Delta to other parts of the state “for use by the people there who desperately need a reliable water supply.”

Trump directed his Interior and Commerce secretaries to report back on their efforts to implement the new policy by April 20. His order left unclear precisely how his administration will seek to carry out that objective.

Karla Nemeth, director of the California Department of Water Resources, said the approach outlined by the

president could do substantial harm by putting water supplies at risk as well as protections for vulnerable fish species.

Nemeth said that Trump’s order, on its own, does not change anything and that the current rules for operating California’s water delivery systems in the Central Valley — which

were supported by the state and adopted by the Biden administration in December — remain in effect.

Presumably, the president is directing the agencies to again start the lengthy process of revising the framework that governs how the two main water delivery systems, the State Wa-

[See Water, A12]

Trump birthright order is blocked

Judge temporarily halts policy ending the constitutional guarantee of citizenship. NATION, A5

In disaster areas, worry now is rain

Fear of landslides grows in the Palisades, Altadena and Rancho Palos Verdes. CALIFORNIA, B1

‘Emilia Pérez’ up for 13 Oscars

“Wicked” and “The Brutalist” earn 10 nominations apiece. ENTERTAINMENT, E1

Weather High clouds. L.A. Basin: 74/47. B6

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